

1.2 Types Of Socialising

We've come a long way from the days of IRC and the BBS. Today, the Internet is just a part of our lives, not something that awes. Instant Messaging and chat were once a novelty; today, we just expect to be able to use these. On a different note, social networking isn't just as simple as making friends. There's a purpose to everything we do these days.

And so, when we network, we have a specific reason to do so. Some of us are just bored and looking for something interesting to read, and that's where blogs come in. Blogging sites are also very much social sites, because the very concept is to share thoughts, ideas, and musings with the world. This results in comments from people who read your posts and your replies to them—and thus you have interaction. So perhaps it's only fair to list blogging down as social networking in its most basic form. We've covered everything you need to know in our earlier *Fast Track to Blogging*, so we don't need to dwell on it further.

The idea behind social networking, strictly speaking, is to grow your list of friends, but as all working professionals know, we have varied levels and types of friends. First come our buddies (our *yaars*), and these are people you just love to hang out with, share thoughts and ideas, and all this is generally casual and playful interaction. Most popular social networking sites involve making such friends. Then there's sexual attraction and flirting and all that, and dating sites are what fill that need. However, most popular social networking sites, too, offer some way of showing amorous interest in other members—that's what all the Flirt, Add To Crush List, Send Flowers, etc., buttons are for. There are tons of adult sites as well, targeted at sexually liberated adults, helping them find each other across the globe. For obvious reasons, we aren't going to talk about such sites.

A very important social activity is work-related networking. Though there's the opportunity to engage in business networking